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Organizational blogging: a case study of a corporate weblog from an employee perspective

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Abstract

Purpose – The aim of this paper is to address and discuss usage and implications of a weblog in a corporate communication context from an employees' perspective.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper is a case study of a government agency's corporate blogging activity, traced through focus group interviews with the organizational bloggers and analyzed using situational analysis and thematic network analysis.

Findings – The study problematizes the predominant focus on the promises of interactivity and dialogue as a repeated positive motivation for corporate bloggers by shedding a light on blogging as experienced from inside an organization. The study shows that employee bloggers use the blog platform in a varied way and do not agree internally on the appropriate corporate blog usage. Four main positions that encapsulate the variation in blog usage – the official, the debater, the engineer and the passionate blogger – are identified, and the implications (opportunities and barriers) of blogging for the blogging employees' behavior and motivation are unfolded and discussed.

Practical implications – The findings are useful for managers to get insight into the challenges, barriers and opportunities, which employees experience when acting as bloggers on behalf of an organization, as well as when acting on other transparent Web 2.0 mediated communications platforms for corporate purposes. The findings also indicate and give recommendations to the internal resources required to support the employees when letting them out into the blogosphere.

Originality/value – The paper provides a documented, nuanced and deep insight and understanding into blog usage in a corporate context from the perspective of the employee bloggers. This insight is as critical to our understanding of blogging and social media in a corporate context, as it is to our understanding of transparent and participatory organizational culture.

Keywords Social media, Employee behaviour, Employee attitudes, Organizational culture, Corporate communications, Corporate blogging

Paper type Case study



1. Introduction

In this paper, the phenomenon of blogging is investigated in a concrete organizational setting, namely the Danish Patent and Trademark Office's weblog, the Intellectual Property blog, called the IP-blog. The government agency started their corporate weblog on IPR (Intellectual Property Rights) in October 2005 with around 20 employee bloggers. The strategic purpose of the blog sprung out of a branding effort as part of an increase in public organizations' digital communication in Denmark. Employees from a broad spectrum of departments within the organization have been selected as bloggers, and they are expected to define, structure and manage how they write on the blog.

At the time when the IP-blog emerged, the field of blogging was dominated by practitioners and consultancy-based literature with a predominant message that companies had to adapt to and implement the blog and other social media forms in their communication if they wanted to be prepared and able to participate in the open and user-generated Web 2.0 technologies represented first by blogs, and later by other social media. The companies were promised a change in business's way of communicating with the publics, *The Cluetrain Manifesto* (Levine *et al.*, 2001) being one of the strongest impetuses for the trend. As Puschmann (2010) critically notes in his work on corporate blogging as an emerging genre of computer-mediated communication, Cluetrain echoes the advice to change your tone from one that pronounces to one that invites participation and to cede some control, and is based on the impression that only a communicative style that emphasizes parity and equality can succeed. The overall mantra expressed a radical shift in the relationship between corporations and consumers from markets as targets to markets as conversation (Kline and Burstein, 2005; Levine *et al.*, 2001; Scoble and Israel, 2006). The popularity and promises of blogs back then were centered on the "tools for conversation" aspect. Journalists and business consultants, Kline and Burstein (2005), argue that the reason blogs embed themselves into our new cultural DNA is that we are living in a unique moment in time when the human urges to converse, communicate, argue publicly, learn collaboratively, share experiences, and archive collective knowledge have suddenly been married with incredibly powerful, fast, ubiquitous technologies, such as the blog. The citizen-expert, the citizen-journalist, and the informed amateur in many realms of knowledge and human endeavor are all gaining prominence as a result of the blogging phenomenon (Kline and Burstein, 2005, p. xiv).

These reactions to the boom in digital interpersonal communication via the Internet all seem to convey that corporate actors should emulate the socio-communicative behavior of their customers to gain trust and be perceived as competent partners and not manipulators. To this, Puschmann (2010) makes the argument that the issue is not seen primarily as ethical but as behavioral: communicate differently and you will be perceived differently, appears to be the tenet (Puschmann, 2010, p. 87). This reasoning sheds an important and necessary critical light on the promises and hyperbole propagated by the Cluetrainers, and shows how it refers more to a change in communicative style (human voice vs corporate monotone) than change in behavior (replacing the motivation to maximize profits with something more benign). In this sense, established genres of corporate communication, such as the mission statement or investor relations report, are cast in a negative light to emphasize how "out of touch" corporations are with the loss of influence and control of access to information that is brought about by the rise of Web 2.0 technologies:

The inherent assumption in public-facing corporate blogging is that the crisis postulated by Cluetrain and reflected in the loss of trust in established corporate communicators and genres can be overcome by adapting to a new environment and practices. Using an external blog to address a wide variety of stakeholders (potential and existing customers, potential employees, public officials, interest groups) means being on par with the perceived democratic nature of the blogosphere; however, it also opens the door to a number of new challenges not present prior to the rise of blogs (Puschmann, 2010, p. 87).

In agreement with Puschmann's critique, which finds the conclusion of the Cluetrainers to be somewhat undocumented, this paper identifies these challenges along with other

central implications on the basis of an explorative investigation of an external blog from the internal bloggers' perspective. While a certain body of research exists on bloggers as social actors and community builders (Miller and Shepherd, 2005), bloggers as agenda-setters on the political scene (Hopkins and Matheson, 2005; Klasttrup and Pedersen, 2006), bloggers as sources for news media (Messner and Distasio, 2008; Metzgar, 2007), bloggers as opinion leaders, role, use and effects of blogging in public relations (Porter *et al.*, 2009; Porter *et al.*, 2007; Kent, 2008), organizational blogs and relational strategies and outcomes (Kelleher and Miller, 2006; Cho and Huh, 2010), executive blogging (Wyld, 2008), as well as blogging in crisis situations (Sweetser and Metzgar, 2007; Thelwall and Stuart, 2007; Valentini and Romenti, 2011), a similar degree of attention has not been given to research on actual blog usage situation from the inside of an organization (Efimova, 2009). These insights into the underlying motives and behaviors reported from an internal blog environment are critical to our understanding of blogging in a corporate context, as well as to our understanding of participatory organizational culture. Identifying the contextual elements and the resources and limitations that companies are bound to encounter when engaging in blogging is an important step towards this understanding.

Taking the point of departure in an explorative, qualitative study based on a social constructivist foundation, focusing on the construction of positions and views on the use of the blog for external communicative purposes in a public authority – namely the Danish Patent and Trademark Office – the locally shaped contextual elements, usage and implications of this form of communication are addressed and discussed at a macro organizational level and a micro conversational level based on the sense making of the employees involved. Hence, the overall aim of this paper is to address blogging from two different perspectives:

- (1) the strategic usage of blogging in a corporate setting from a corporate communication perspective; and
- (2) the discursively constructed usage of blogging on the basis of blogging employees' sense making of their own blog activity, and the implications thereof.

The first section of this paper offers a brief review of the various definitions and uses of blogs in organizational and corporate settings. The review generates an overview of some of the central research into blogging in corporate contexts and presents relevant aspects of corporate communications in relation to blogging. In the following section, the methodological decisions and steps taken in the design of the case study and data gathering process are presented. Next, the data analysis is presented and the locally shaped contextual elements, the usage and implications in the form of possibilities and limitations of the blog as reflected on by employee bloggers are addressed and discussed. In the final part of the paper, I conclude on the empirical findings, the practical implications, limitations and future research.

2. Blogging in an organizational context

Weblogs are some of the first examples of the so-called Web 2.0 technologies and social media. In contrast to Web 1.0, which was about defining and creating destinations for web users, Web 2.0 is about people and content. According to O'Reilly, Web 2.0 is:

[...] the network as platform, spanning all connected devices, [...] delivering software as a continually-updated service that gets better the more people use it, consuming and remixing data from multiple sources, including individual users, while providing their own data and services in a form that allows remixing by others, creating network effects through an “architecture of participation” and going beyond the page metaphor of Web 1.0 to deliver rich user experiences (O’Reilly, 2005, p. 13).

Rich user experiences are not only the result of social networking *per se*, but especially of user generated content (Von Kortzfleisch *et al.*, 2007). In the corporate environment, Web 2.0 users are mainly employees who voluntarily add comments on corporate blogs, add their knowledge to corporate wikis, distribute their search results with the help of social bookmarking systems, or add information about their expertise areas to their social networking profiles (Von Kortzfleisch *et al.*, 2007).

2.1 Defining the blog

The first studies of blogging primarily established criteria for the categorization of blogs according to their form and content in a genre perspective (Blood, 2002; Herring *et al.*, 2004), or measured the influence of blogs on politics via specific audiences (Drezner and Farrell, 2004, cited in Puschmann, 2010, p. 24). Puschmann argues that blogs “in general” are not well-suited for a classification in terms of genre, because no single discourse community can be named that produces them, no single purpose is associated with their production and no fixed stylistic conventions have yet emerged for them, but we are still able to identify them via their presentation and structure (Puschmann, 2010, p. 25). I agree with Puschmann that giving blogs an image of what constitutes a “good” or “typical” instantiation of a specific genre is problematic since the style and content of a blog entry is determined to a large extent by the purposes the blogger associates with the post. In accordance with this view, Efimova (2009) points to the difficulty of defining weblogs as a consequence of their authors having different goals, uses, and writing styles, with only one thing in common: format (Efimova, 2009, p. 2). The following hands-on definition from a blogger matches Puschmann’s comparison of the personal blog with the corporate blog:

A blog is a personal diary. A daily pulpit. A collaborative space. A political soapbox. A breaking-news outlet. A collection of links. Your own private thoughts. Memos to the world. Your blog is whatever you want it to be. (“What’s a blog” 2/5 2006, in: Hoff-Clausen, 2008, pp. 138-139).

In his comparison between the personal and the corporate blog, Puschmann concludes that the subjective non-threatening and non-suasive attributes associated with personal blogging are deliberately sought by corporate bloggers in an effort to counter a growing negative perception of corporate public-facing communication as deceptive, manipulative and impersonal, as referred to earlier (Puschmann, 2010, p. 21). On the basis of the long and ever-changing definition of a weblog on Wikipedia, Puschmann pinpoints the relevant struggle when it comes to defining blogs of whether to define them primarily in terms of technology (a web site), structure (entries, reverse chronological order; Herring *et al.*, 2004), authorship (usually maintained by an individual), content (descriptions of events, commentary or news on particular subject or opinion), interactivity (the ability of readers to leave comments), or genre (personal diary). In light of all these uses and different angles for defining the weblog, Wikipedia has opted for an amalgam of all aspects (Puschmann, 2010, p. 13), similar to the

informal, hands-on definition above. Turning to the use of a blog for definitions in their work with the organizational use of blogging, Baxter *et al.* (2010), on the basis of Lee *et al.* (2006), identify five types of blogs: employee blogs, group blogs, executive blogs (e.g. CEO blogs), promotional blogs, and newsletter blogs. Employee blogs are often associated with staff members' blogging externally on behalf of their company so as to maintain a favorable image for the company. Group blogs are mostly used for project-related purposes of both an internal and external nature. Executive or CEO blogs are run by company executives to put forward company ideas and engage with members of the public through feedback; and, promotional blogs are used specifically for advertising products while newsletter blogs deal with issues relating to company information (Baxter *et al.*, 2010). What is interesting about the case study organization presented in this paper is that on their blog all these uses are embedded and represented (with exception of the CEO blog). The Danish Patent and Trademark Office's blog is a team-authored blog; its purpose is both image creation through branding as well as providing news, information sharing, and promoting the agency's expertise and courses in patent counseling, as well as other top-down and bottom-up purposes in one and the same blog. In light of these apparent difficulties in defining the weblog, Puschmann's simple working definition of a corporate blog attracts and fits the purpose of this study: "A (primarily textual) blog used in an institutional context to further organizational goals" (Puschmann, 2010, p. 15).

As regards the more specific use of blogs as tools for corporate communication, Catalano (2007) places them within the strategic practice of producing symbols or messages. He points to the usefulness of blogs for positioning corporations in the marketplace of discourse that corporate communicators enter for the purpose of adjusting their organization to their environment and vice versa (Catalano, 2007, p. 249). Catalano underlines why blogs in particular are considered significant to consider in corporate communication. First, they have led futurists and journalists to predict the demise of traditional media and to proclaim that blogs are akin to what he entitles "Internet-style megaphones". Second, Catalano stresses how blogs have demonstrated their usefulness for private citizens and government officials in successfully disseminating information; raising awareness; engaging in public dialogue; influencing or managing reputations, crises, and issues; and building communities (Catalano, 2007). When examining whether organizations can use blogs for these same purposes, Catalano concludes that "corporations in the US and abroad can take advantage of blogging by creating guidelines, implementing a monitoring-and-analysis program" which more specifically will help in identifying opinion leaders, potential crises, and key issues as they emerge in the blogosphere, and promote dialogue and foster trust among key stakeholders (Catalano, 2007, p. 256). Another important conclusion of Catalano relevant to this paper's case study analysis is that the discussion dimension is not necessarily the DNA of a blog, which can also thrive on merely having an audience. Another relevant feature of blogs is their ability to gain a daily readership to promote particular ideas and attract the attention of mainstream media (Hearn *et al.*, 2009, p. 53). Further, Catalano concludes that in an environment where corporations are scrutinized more closely, held to higher standards of accountability and are being accused of not being open and honest in terms of their communications, the number of bloggers who espouse their thoughts, opinions, and

findings regarding the practices, products, and services of companies will continue to increase (Catalano, 2007, p. 258).

To sum up, in the case study presented in this paper, the blog is considered a discursively and narratively constructed open “room” within a corporate setting, in which the sense making and context of this room is what leads to a higher degree of understanding of the phenomenon.

2.2 Aspects of blogging and corporate communication

Organizations are networks of people who communicate with each other. In all organizations communications flow vertically and horizontally, internally and externally, formally and informally, linking employees internally to each other, to various layers of management, and to the many external resource-holders of the organization (Van Riel and Fombrun, 2007, p. 13). The Danish Patent and Trademark Office's blog has proven to embrace all of these layers of the organization's communication, and therefore is a relevant example of the complexity of communicating externally with a broad spectrum of stakeholders, as well as increasing transparency internally. This paper takes on the view of corporate communication to include internal communication, management communication, organizational communication, and market communication, since the overall strategy of the IP-blog follows van Riel and Fombrun's broad definition of corporate communication as the total communication activity generated by a company to achieve its planned objectives (from Jackson, 1987; cited in Van Riel and Fombrun, 2007, p. 25). The blog is strategically aimed at all these communicative activities at one time.

A very important element becomes central in this aspect, i.e. transparency. With the advent of new communication technologies, like the weblog and other internet applications, organizations partly driven by these technologies, like the Danish Patent and Trademark Office in their increased digital communications efforts, are expected to contribute to transparency themselves by sharing relevant information with their surroundings. Transparency, thus, is an essential dimension of contemporary organizations' understanding of themselves and their communication strategies (Christensen, 2002, p. 163). Whereas the corporate communication manager seeks to conceptualize the organization as a totality of interconnected messages, the corporate culture endeavor is focused on myths, rituals and stories articulated and managed in order to integrate the organization's members around one shared reality. According to Christensen, the endeavors of unity and cohesion are easier to attain if the “shared” dimensions of the organization are not articulated too explicitly. Christensen argues how ambiguity can be ironically productive because it allows the coexistence of several perspectives within one organizational unity, and the intensification in communication associated with projects of transparency leads to the exposure of pluralism, to a multiplicity of voices (Christensen, 2002, pp. 164-165):

While careful self-examinations and self-evaluations can be extremely valuable and generate important insight about internal processes, it would be erroneous to assume that such exercises make organizations transparent to themselves as one whole entity [...] The notion of a whole or unity, thus, is simply one local representation among other possible local representations (Christensen, 2002, p. 165).

The analysis of this paper unfolds this internal process of a highly transparent communication effort, the IP-blog, in which a variety of these local representatives are

present – from the engineers and the marketing people to the legal consultants – where all members of the blog community bring their messages and stories to the blog. A multifaceted, ambiguous communication universe, in contrast to the holistic idea of unity in corporate communications strategy, is showing, in which negotiations between employee bloggers of its usage are unfolded, revealing the boundaries of blogs to be socially constructed. This view of communication goes further than the application of the container metaphor utilized in orthodox corporate communication theory. Corporate communication then is not viewed as a means for transporting information from one place to another, but as a process in which the company itself is constructed. Indeed, the company then can be defined as “a social collective” produced, reproduced, and transformed through the ongoing, interdependent, and goal-oriented communication practices of its members (Mumby and Claire, 1997; cited in Hübner, 2007, p. 20). In this sense, corporate communication is best understood through the corporate communication discourses that are constitutive for the organization:

Corporate communication needs to be analyzed in a practical environment, which embraces actors, structures and activities in order to reveal the full interplay between these constituents in strategic, i.e. communicational practice (Hübner, 2007, p. 24).

Baxter and Connolly (2013) have made a recent study on the state of art of organizational blogging. On the basis of a systematic literature review, their conclusion is that blog research into organizational blogging is increasing, but research in the subject area is still in its infancy with a lack of empirical research that explores the background, decision-making processes and organizational factors affecting the impact on adoption and use of blogs. Hence, empirical evidence of Web 2.0 use within an actual organization is needed which will be of great benefit to management practitioners who will be able to learn from specific case studies and apply the knowledge learnt from them to introduce blogs into their own organizations (Baxter and Connolly, 2013, p. 113). As an example of a study of this kind, Baxter and Connolly point to a study of blogging in internal communication by Kosonen *et al.* (2007) in which the application of blogs for internal communication in a large engineering company is explored. The case study examined the factors that can affect the use of internal blogs in corporate environments, and the conclusion is drawn that blogs are used in internal communication to achieve strategy-implementation goals and to stimulate information interactions. Corporate climate and culture are particular factors that determine the successful implementation of blogs.

The present case study adds to the research called for by Baxter and Connolly on the behavioral implications of organizational blogging and responds to this need for analyzing a practical environment and its actors, structures and activities by showing and discussing the several positions identified in the analysis of the IP-bloggers, who represent different stances on how the blog should be used. Hence, the analysis helps us understand the local shapes and forms organizational blog-communication takes in a specific interactional context. Naturally, a complete investigation would also include the external blog participants and an analysis of the blog text to embrace what Hübner refers to as the communicational practice. However, undertaking these analytical steps is considered a natural next phase of this study.

3. Case study of the Danish Patent and Trademark Office's weblog

The data used in this paper originate from an empirical case study of the Danish Patent and Trademark Office's weblog, the IP-blog. The Danish Patent and Trademark Office (DKPTO) is part of the Danish Ministry of Business and Growth and holds the authority to issue patent and design rights and register trademarks in Denmark. The DKPTO employs about 200 people and is a hierarchically structured organization. The organization entered the blogosphere in 2005, when blogs were an almost unknown phenomenon in a Danish organizational context, and hence, hold the title as corporate blog-pioneers and the first government agency in Denmark to engage in blogging. For this explorative study, the case of DKPTO was considered relevant since it provides access to organizational bloggers' longitudinal experience with the medium, providing a nuanced and deep understanding of the phenomenon, primarily from an employees' perspective. Around 35 bloggers are active on the IP-blog, and I was in contact with 24 of them during the three-year study.

The methodological approach is qualitative and the study is intensive rather than extensive. I am concerned with empirical work rather than large-scale theory development. Positioning in this analysis is the discursive production of selves on the blog. In accordance with the purpose of the paper, the usage and implications (i.e. limitations and resources) involved in the highly contextual diversity of the blog-setting are traced through focus group interviews of 19 of the organizational bloggers, divided in four focus groups of four to six respondents each. The focus groups constitute the primary source of data and were supplemented by individual semi-structured interviews and continuous observation of the blog posts and internal strategic documents regarding the IP-blog. This approach led to focus groups that were highly organized regarding setting, but explorative in content and inductively giving room to the participants' interpretations, views, reflections, opinions and internal discussions on blog usage within the organization.

Focusing on the internal blog participants, the analytical process takes an interpretative approach based on DKPTO-bloggers' perceptions and sense making of their blog usage. What is constituted in the focus groups is focus group interaction about the everyday practice, and this practice (talking about the blog usage) is interpreted on the basis of the underlying motives and articulations of uses. The results reflect what the IP-bloggers make of communication when practiced in their own way, when understood through their own terms and through their own explanations. How is the blog-communication conducted, conceived and evaluated among the organizational bloggers in DKPTO? Data analysis of these motivations in the form of themes and patterns is conducted through the use of thematic network analysis in a discourse analytical perspective:

Discourse theory is the reflective understanding of the means which have already demonstrated their value in practice by raising them to the level of explicit consciousness (Howarth and Torfing, 2004, p. 317).

Discourse research in this sense offers routes into the study of meanings, a way of investigating the back-and-forth dialogues, which constitute social action, along with the patterns of signification, and representation which constitute culture (Wetherell *et al.*, 2001). Overall, discourse analysis has to do with a close study of language in use and patterns.

3.1 *Situational- and thematic network analysis*

Thematic network analysis (Attride-Stirling, 2001) is the primary method of analysis of the focus group data. Thematic network analysis (TNA) is a method of identifying, organizing and structuring themes, a step-by-step guide which is practical and useful for this kind of investigation where hundreds of codes (themes) emerge from the rich user experiences and narratives of the IP-bloggers. Thematic analyses and thematic networks are equally applicable in analyses with a focus on commonalities, differences or contradictions, and it is up to the researcher to identify themes in a manner that is appropriate to their specific theoretical interests (Attride-Stirling, 2001, p. 395). Thematic analysis is a relatively straightforward form of qualitative analysis, which does not require the same detailed theoretical and technical knowledge as approaches like content analysis. However, rich description and interpretation are crucial for the analysis to succeed, e.g. it is of high importance to provide adequate examples from the data. In this context, a theme represents some level of patterned response or meaning within the data set (Braun and Clarke, 2006, p. 82). Thus, my approach to the concept of theme is when something important about the data in relation to the research purpose (addressing the local context and the usage and implications of organizational blogging from the employee's perspective) is captured. Like Attride-Stirling, who has developed the qualitative method, I am interested in the themes that are common in all the conducted focus groups; therefore, the more common are given precedence. This criterion for selection is not intended to attribute greater overall explanatory value to themes on a quantitative basis, it simply makes it possible to focus attention on the common homogenous popular themes which is the specific interest of the study (Attride-Stirling, 2001, p. 395). The main criteria for this type of analysis are connection, usefulness and transparency. To supplement the TNA, situational analysis (SA) (Clarke, 2005), which embraces a broad set of contextual elements at a macro level, is used on the basis that the analysis of local contextual elements of the blog usage and its implications are crucial for understanding the communicative purposes, usage and implications of blogging as experienced by the employees.

To sum up the design of the study, both SA and TNA are applied to the reflexive texts (focus group transcripts). SA is used for identifying contextual organizational elements – the things on the blog referring to the local macro level (e.g. stakeholder perceptions, departmental structure, target audience) – and TNA offers intertextuality in the identification of the discursive themes in the focus group texts at a micro level. The combination of the two data analysis techniques provides the opportunity of establishing a discursive context in the understanding of the blog-practice as highly situated locally, establishing the context and description of the predominant situational elements that constitute the IP-blog, and conducting a categorization of the organizational bloggers' construction of themes in relation to their blog practice regarding usage and implications. From a deconstruction of the focus groups, four thematic networks are constructed containing the different levels of decontextualized themes. The thematic networks resemble a categorization of the main themes, as expressed in the form of opinions and views of the internal bloggers, in global themes, organizing themes and basic themes, not forming a hierarchy but a network.

4. The perceived usage, implications and discursive positions of the employee bloggers

There is no single motivation for blogging, but different groups of users, within the same organization, and often the same department, bring very different conceptualizations of the practice to the table. The contextually bounded motivations are varied and depend crucially on the target audience, communicative goals and on how the individual conceptualizes blogging. In accordance with the reluctance to narrowly define the corporate blog, I will not label the types of blogging on the IP-blog into categories as topic-blogging or ego-blogging (Puschmann, 2010), but instead focus on the main usages and implications by extracting the central discursive themes and locating different discursive positions taken on the blog. From a corporate communication perspective, it is interesting that in spite of a strategic document containing general guidelines, and a disclaimer to protect the employee bloggers from being personally attacked on the blog, no coordinated plan or strategy has been followed in the almost seven years of blogging in the Danish Patent and Trademark Office. When confronting the blog participants with the strategy, very few are aware of its existence, and the responsible blog coordinator informs us that people are briefly introduced to it when they start blogging, but other than that it is intentionally hidden away, and no rules or training are implemented. Hence, the “open” communication technology represented by the blog leaves open a discussion among the employees of the blog’s autonomous usage, and the focus groups of the present study represent such an open discussion forum. It becomes clear from the analysis that the difficulties of merging an organic blog movement from a bottom-up approach with a structured communications hierarchy managed top-down is clearly confusing and frustrating for several bloggers, giving rise to discussions of what kind of blog-content is most apt. The analysis also shows that these disagreements are highly related to locally contextual elements such as the departmental structures and the work tasks of the bloggers, which vary greatly. The bloggers have created internal blog communities within the organization dependent on what departments they are affiliated with. Other investigations show how conflicts can emerge from disputes between employee bloggers and management over what is appropriate blogging content (Lee *et al.*, 2006). In the case of DKPTO, the employee bloggers are the ones representing counter discourses on the appropriate blog content, whereas the CEO of the agency seems to share the mantra of the Cluetrainers, as mentioned in the introduction to this paper, which suggests “the more blogging the better”. Like one slightly irritated employee commented during a focus group: “Everything has to go on that blog”. In this context, a discussion of control versus autonomy in blogging is manifested on the IP-blog since the bloggers engage in constant processes of negotiation and need to strike a balance between control and autonomy. Some argue that the wide and “loose” frames, which the employee bloggers are supposed to blog under, are damaging to the image of the organization, while others consider the personal freedom as highly motivating.

Three predominant situational factors are present on the IP-blog: trust, delegated responsibility and freedom. At first sight, these attributes could seem to have a positive ring to them when considering the corporate context as described in section two of the paper. However, the trust, delegated responsibility and freedom come with certain constraints and barriers. For some corporate bloggers, these situational factors are a positive part of their organizational life, whereas others find it difficult to manage and

handle, and they tend to put constraints on themselves. As a result of that strategic ambiguity, the organizational members enact a culture in which self-direction, for some, functions as a constraint rather than a freedom (Putnam and Fairhurst, 2001, p. 112).

Having addressed some of the main local, contextual and structural elements influencing the blog behavior and motivations, I now turn to the identification of the usage and implications of the blog constructed by the IP-bloggers. For that purpose, I inductively establish four thematic networks, which reflect the most central aspects of the application of the IP-blog. Besides the two thematic networks on the usage of the IP-blog, I have developed two networks on the primary implications of blogging. I refer to these as the limitations and resources of the blog:

- (1) the blog as information channel (pin board vs. agenda creator);
- (2) the blog as communication channel (versatile universe vs. comments and dialogue);
- (3) limitations of the blog (self-censorship and organizational barriers); and
- (4) the blog as a resource (possibilities and signal value).

As seen from the overarching themes identified, the IP-bloggers use the blog both as a one-way channel of information and a two-way channel of communication. On the basis of these networks, I isolate a distinction in the general approach to the application of blogs between a more reactive and sender-oriented position and a more proactive and receiver-oriented position. Concerning the implications of the blog, a distinction between focusing upon the limitations of the blog and focusing upon the blog as a resource is visible from the focus group interviews.

To elaborate on these primary usages and implications that the thematic networks revealed, discursive positions, which are taken on the blog, are identified and summed up in Table I:

Each position has at least one prototypical representative among the participants in the interviews, but many participants adopt more than one position.

Among the many implications of blogging that this case study has revealed are the barriers to blogging that the organizational bloggers experience. The thematic network analysis of their motivations show that there are what I frame as organizational limitations, such as the work structure of the department, time and resource limitations, and the constant evaluation by the blogger of what is allowed to be said publicly, and what is not. In many cases this leads to self-censorship among the organizational bloggers, which is a widespread consequence of being a public authority, and in many cases traces back to the official government agency culture. However, it also has to do with the individual's motivation in relation to their work functions. The analysis shows that the extrinsically motivated bloggers, the ones that are only blogging because management has told them to, are less passionate bloggers than the intrinsically motivated bloggers who have a passion for the blog and use it proactively to build an agenda on, e.g. EU-regulated matters that are difficult to explain to users elsewhere. There are empirical findings of organizational bloggers that started out as predominantly extrinsically motivated (e.g. the manager told them to blog), but who, over time, have become intrinsically motivated bloggers (considering

Primary discursive positions and motives of the IP-bloggers				Organizational blogging
The official	The debater	The engineer	The passionate	
Reactive usage	Marketing tool	Variation in work	Proactive usage	45
Pin board	Transparency and	"Breathing space"	Strategic usage	
Official messages (before the	visibility are	Entertainment value	Build an agenda	
blog they were sent by	important	(e.g. a weekly contest	Move a discussion in	
Proactive usage	elements	on guessing a patent)	another direction	
Strategic usage	Multifaceted and	Information- and	Impact and nuance the	
Build an agenda	varied usage give	knowledge sharing	public debate on areas	
Move a discussion in another	high signal value		of professional interest	
direction	Do not feel		Channel for expert	
Impact and nuance the public	limitations		knowledge	
debate on areas of professional	Wants an open		Resource in daily work	
interest	debate, also a		Knowledge creation tool	
Channel for expert knowledge	critical one		Personal information	
Resource in daily work	Deals with		archive	
Knowledge creation tool	criticism and		Time saver	
Personal information archive	discussions		Visibility of	
Time saver	openly		competences	
Visibility of				
competences(letter)				
Documentation				
Primary motivation: Reach				
goals (set out by management)				
Writing in the traditional				
authority manner and style				
Official corporate culture				
Not interested in feedback				
"Keep out of trouble" (better				
not to engage in debate, than				
to have it get out of control)				
Time consumer (guilty				
conscience about not writing)				

Table I.
Overview of the
discursive positions and
the motives of the
IP-bloggers

the blog to be a resource in their professional work and creating value in their job function as well as being an effective tool in communication with stakeholders).

The most common use of the blog within the Danish Patent and Trademark Office is as a reference tool and a pin board, and the predominant discursive position is the official blogger (cf. Table I). Others regard the blog as a diary-like document that brings stories to life that are clearly in the periphery of official communication to key stakeholders, and hence difficult to categorize according to the traditional communication tools in the company. Through the focus group interviews, an internal disagreement on whether or not the polyphonic character of the blog is to be considered a resource or a risk is evident and results in *counter discourses*. In this paper, I highlight the two most prominent of these counter discourses, namely the enthusiastic blogger vs the skeptical blogger. The enthusiastic blogger argues that the organization has much to gain from being seen as open and transparent (this discursive position is mainly represented by the debater, cf. Table I). The skeptical blogger is more concerned with the image of the organization when it blogs about all

kinds of information – some of it bordering on “banalities” and perhaps not being serious enough. The skeptical blogger is primarily concerned with how the agency is being perceived by the external audience when topics that are (in their opinion) bordering on irrelevant are presented on the blog (this discursive position is represented by the official, cf. Table I). The skeptical blogger fears that the blog portrays the organization as unholistic and fragmented, and hence he or she seeks to control and create alignment between the messages and content on the blog in order for DKPTO to maintain what this blogger perceives as the image of a serious organization.

Despite the many counter discourses and disagreements on the blog usage and the differences in perceived implications, the employee bloggers across different positions share and agree on five perceived advantages, strengths and value-creating elements of the blog, compared to traditional communications forms. These are:

- (1) easier access to external users;
- (2) increase in visibility of the individual employee and his/her competences;
- (3) potential informality in writing style;
- (4) giving a human face to the organization; and
- (5) easy and uncomplicated information and knowledge sharing (linking being a highly valued tool in this connection).

Regarding the first finding listed here, the access level is lower and the communication is more direct on a blog. The bloggers agree that the blog-format provides a highly direct way of communicating, especially compared to other communication forms in the organization. The transparent nature of the blog has mainly led to an increase in visibility of the individual employee, and has not to the same degree resulted in the creation of more relations and networks, although some bloggers confuse the increased visibility with network-creation. The conclusion is that the blog itself does not create networks, but can be a facilitator and supplement to the creation of networks in other relations (e.g. when meeting stakeholders at conferences or when talking to clients or other stakeholders on the phone).

Besides these perceived advantages of the IP-blog, the analysis also problematizes the predominant focus on interactivity and dialogue as a repeated positive motivation for bloggers. The relational aspect that both practitioners and researchers highlight as influential features of Web 2.0 communications is not nearly as dominant in the usage of the IP-blog as would be expected from the literature reviewed in the first part of the paper. For instance, not all employee bloggers want the dialogue, but consider other uses of the blog more important, the dialogical aspect being just a (sometimes unwanted) side effect. The IP-blog has many readers (around 8-9,000 a month, 2010), and for several bloggers it is enough to know that the external audience reads the blog. They do not need them to comment as it is not part of the culture. This shows that the general premise for using a blog is not necessarily interactive and the comments from external participants are in many cases less than fruitful for the internal blog user. One blogger comments that “these people [the ones commenting on the posts] are not people I wish to engage with in any kind of relation or network”. He continues: “Handling the external comments is one of the biggest challenges of being a blogger”. Furthermore, the study problematizes the company’s usage of a blog because there are several barriers, and those barriers are highly dependent on the organizational culture and the

internal communication environment among other things. The focus groups present examples of bloggers who have changed their blog behavior from an informal, “entertaining” approach to a more official and serious approach because of internal critics (the skeptical counter discourse). Although Cluetrainers and Web 2.0 evangelists stress the fact that companies need to let go of the traditional approach to communication when they enter the blogosphere, the present study shows that this proves to be difficult in practice, because when they do, they might be met with a highly critical audience, both externally and internally, and the individual blogger often faces difficulties addressing this negative feedback, which for some is considered a demotivating factor.

To conclude the paper, combining the usage and implications with the discursive positions identified, the study proposes four dominant social implications of organizational blogging in the form of distinct discursive behaviors:

- (1) self-restriction behavior in expression;
- (2) interaction-oriented behavior;
- (3) information-sharing behavior; and
- (4) knowledge-expert disseminating behavior.

5. Conclusion

Based on a review of blogging in a corporate context related to corporate communication practice and the presentation of a qualitative case study of a group of employees’ blog usage, this paper has approached an emerging online communication tool with a strategic purpose within a corporate communication context, i.e. corporate blogging. The paper has presented an analysis of the communicative situation in which reflections and perceptions of the primary contextual parameters that influence employee bloggers in the decisions they make as bloggers are identified, and their reflections and views on the usage and implications of blogging as regards resources and limitations are presented and discussed.

In the review, the strategic usage of blogging in a corporate setting is approached and discussed, as well as key issues such as the effects of the boom in digital interpersonal communication. Corporate blogging opens the door to a new set of challenges for the corporate communication function. However, there has been a tendency, particularly in the practitioners’ literature, to almost exclusively focus on the need for companies to engage and take advantage of the opportunities of blog (and other Web 2.0) technology. Transparency is addressed as one of the central elements following the new communication technology, of which the corporate blog is a representative example. Drawing on these key issues, the paper identifies and explores these challenges by analyzing the bloggers within the Danish Patent and Trademark Office’s underlying reflections on their motives and behavior on the blog. The analysis sheds light on the multifaceted meanings, differences and similarities, and the paradoxes and counter discourses of organizational blogging when unfolded from inside an organization. A categorization of the dominant themes on blog usage and implications as experienced and discursively constructed by the employee bloggers shows that the resources of blogging are typically focused on the possibilities that the IP-blog bring, such as an easy and direct way of addressing the external audience, both as a one-way channel of information and a two-way channel of communication.

However, these apparent resources at the same time reveal how the employee bloggers experience limitations in the form of self-censorship and organizational barriers towards this direct way of communicating and receiving feedback from the audience. What is considered an advantage by one blogger might very well be a disadvantage by another blogger, stressing the highly subjective character of the blog, also in a corporate setting with a common strategic goal. To highlight this multifaceted usage of the corporate blog from within an organization, four discursive blog-positions are presented in the paper: the official, the debater, the engineer, and the passionate. The analysis indicates that, despite a streamlined corporate communication effort in the classic public communication of a government agency, the blog includes a variety of not very homogenous blog content due to its format and broad spectrum of individual writers. This manifold content and heterogeneous blog usage is embraced by the DKPTO top management but confuses many employee bloggers, and in some cases makes them feel insecure and demotivated in relation to the blog.

Research into the implications of corporate blogging from an employees' perspective through a qualitative, in-depth investigation, contributes to a nuanced and documented perspective on the blog-usage and its implications in an organizational setting. Moreover, the investigation contributes to the development of further understanding of the resources and challenges, respectively, that bloggers inside an organization, who blog for official external purposes, are faced with. Furthermore, the analysis contributes with insights into the (good and the bad) experiences of the employees in managing being a blogger. The employees' reflections on the organizational blog allow the organization to (re)define their strategy of transparency and their boundaries between "inside" and "outside", between openness and closure.

5.1 Implications for communication practice

Having given voices to an internal corporate blog community, the present paper contributes with knowledge on motivation in the context of internal organizational blogging and use case scenarios where blogs can be applied and "best practice" which can inform management practitioners how to implement internal blogs in their companies. More specifically, managers who have or are planning to establish a corporate blog should focus on the employees as bloggers, allocating time and resources to prepare and listen continuously to what motivates them and make sure they are comfortable with their role as a blogger. In the allocation of time and resources, an internal "safety net" or discussion forum is crucial for employee bloggers. They need to have the possibility to discuss and find solutions to the sometimes rather difficult task of blogging in coordination with others. This forum can have the purpose of encouraging and motivating the bloggers to share stories and experiences on the blog, and motivating them to read and post messages (for instance, knowing that their colleagues actually follow and read what they are writing). And, at the same time, the forum should make room for and address internal disagreement. Regarding the blog strategy, flexibility is needed to embrace the changing environment of the blog. On the one side, giving the employees the freedom to blog is considered a clear advantage; on the other side, some bloggers find it difficult to manage that freedom. Addressing these issues is of high relevance, not only for blogging practice, but also for all kinds of open-source technology that is implemented in organizations and which includes transparency and interactional elements that the individual employees have to manage and deal with.

5.2 Research limitations and future research

I consider the people behind blogging as the primary interest, and interviews as the main data resource, analyzing the underlying motives and the participants' interpretation of their practice. The study does not include a systematic empirical analysis of blogs themselves. Such an analysis would be highly relevant to get a more complete insight into the social practice of blogging. A future methodological step would be a process of action research. Since action research offers a methodological framework that combines explicit stages of research and reflection with phases of implementation and evaluation, and fosters the participation and engagement of external stakeholders (Hearn *et al.*, 2009), this approach would provide even more in-depth knowledge of the organization's interpretation and implementation of blogging and provide a useful way of including an analysis of the external audience of the blog and its implications. Furthermore, the paper reflects on the blog usage in one specific organization and does not examine the blog usage within multiple organizations, which would also be a relevant future research area. Last, agreeing with Baxter and Connolly (2013), the case study of an actual blog practice provides an opportunity for comparisons and generalizations among different industry sectors to assess whether introducing blogs into certain disciplines proves to be more challenging than others (Baxter and Connolly, 2013, p. 113). Hence, a study of these various industry sectors' use of blogging would be an important future research step.

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Further reading

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